



Call cheat sheet

The 30 core terms, grouped by what they're about: what each one is, why the owner cares, and a line you could use on a call. Keep it open beside the call and use Find (Ctrl+F or Cmd+F) to jump to a term.

Six categories: [Revenue and profit](#) · [Pricing and rates](#) · [Demand and booking timing](#) · [Direct bookings and distribution](#) · [Marketing measurement](#) · [Tools and systems](#).

01 Revenue and profit

What the place earns, what it keeps, and what it's worth.

ADR

[average daily rate](#)

Room revenue divided by rooms sold — the average price a sold room actually went for.

FORMULA Room revenue ÷ Rooms sold

WHY THE OWNER CARES

The clearest read on pricing power. A rising ADR means guests will pay more; a flat or falling ADR next to rising occupancy often means the property is discounting to fill rooms.

ON A CALL

Your ADR held up nicely this month — the question is whether the discounting on quiet nights is pulling it down.

RevPAR

[revenue per available room](#)

Rate and fill in one number; what owners reach for when asked how the year is going.

FORMULA Room revenue ÷ Rooms available (= ADR × Occupancy)

WHY THE OWNER CARES

The standard topline health check and the number owners quote as 'how we're doing'. Its blind spot: it treats a commission-free direct booking and a heavily commissioned OTA booking exactly the same.

ON A CALL

RevPAR tells us rate and fill together, so we're not fooled by a full house sold too cheap.

Ancillary revenue

Everything a guest spends beyond the room — food and beverage, spa, activities, add-ons — and the lever marketing can move without touching rate.

WHY THE OWNER CARES

At an amenity-rich resort the spa, restaurant, events and add-ons can be a large share of the business — room revenue 'can be less than half the picture' — so it's revenue the owner can grow without touching the room rate.

ON A CALL

Rooms are only part of the story here — how much of your ancillary revenue comes from the spa and dinner?

NOI

net operating income

GOP less management fees and fixed charges; what owners and buyers price the property on. USALI now labels this line EBITDA.

FORMULA $\text{NOI} = \text{GOP} - \text{management fees} - \text{fixed charges}$

WHY THE OWNER CARES

The number a buyer prices the property on, so it carries the owner's long-term dream: a business worth a lot more one day, whether they sell or not.

ON A CALL

When you think about selling or expanding one day, NOI is the number the buyer will look at first.

Flow-through

How much of each extra dollar of revenue actually reaches profit rather than being eaten by cost.

FORMULA $\text{Change in GOP} \div \text{Change in revenue}$

WHY THE OWNER CARES

Answers 'of the extra revenue you drove, how much did I actually keep?' — the difference between being busier and being better off.

ON A CALL

More revenue is only good news if it flows through — what's the flow-through on the extra bookings from the promotion?

Cap rate

The yield a buyer prices the property at, applied to NOI.

FORMULA $\text{NOI} \div \text{Purchase price}$

WHY THE OWNER CARES

Turns NOI into a property value, so every dollar added to NOI adds many dollars to what the owner's life's work is worth.

ON A CALL

A higher NOI at the same cap rate means the property is worth more — that's the long game.

02 Pricing and rates

Who sets the rate, what it's measured against, and the demand it wins or loses.

Revenue management

the function

The job itself; at this ICP it may be the owner, a part-timer, or an outsourced firm.

WHY THE OWNER CARES

Tells you who actually sets the rates, and so who you need on the call when pricing comes up — often the owner themselves, which means they feel every pricing decision personally.

ON A CALL

Who handles revenue management for you right now — you, someone on the team, or an outside firm?

Comp set

The set of properties an owner benchmarks against, and the basis of every index on an STR report.

WHY THE OWNER CARES

Less a metric than a lens: who an owner names as their competition shows how they see themselves, which tells you what story and positioning to lean into.

ON A CALL

Who's in your comp set? I'd like to see who you're measuring yourself against before we talk about rate.

Denial Demand that tried to book a date and could not because it was sold out.	WHY THE OWNER CARES Proof that demand exists and was turned away, which is the strongest case an owner can see for raising rates on those dates or adding capacity. ON A CALL <i>If you're turning people away on peak weekends, that denial is demand we can price for, not just celebrate.</i>
Regret Demand that looked at a date and left without booking, usually on price or restriction.	WHY THE OWNER CARES Demand that saw the price and walked away. It tells the owner whether a soft date is a price problem or an awareness problem, which decides whether to discount or to market. ON A CALL <i>Lots of people are looking at those dates and leaving — that's regret, and it usually points to price or a minimum stay.</i>
Orphan night A single night left stranded between two bookings, too short for most guests to want.	WHY THE OWNER CARES Hard to sell once it's stranded, so it's lost revenue unless someone acts early with an offer or a relaxed minimum stay. ON A CALL <i>That single Tuesday between two bookings is an orphan night — a small offer could turn it into revenue.</i>
Rate parity A contractual commitment not to undercut an OTA's rate — Expedia or Booking.com, say — on your own site.	WHY THE OWNER CARES Decides what the owner can offer on their own site. With parity in their OTA contracts, they compete on value-adds and demand, not on a cheaper price. ON A CALL <i>Does your Booking.com contract include rate parity? That decides what we can offer on your own site.</i>

03 Demand and booking timing

When guests book, and what a future date is really worth.

Lead time How far ahead of arrival a booking is made; it differs sharply by date class and by segment.	WHY THE OWNER CARES Peak and holiday dates tend to book further out than midweek and shoulder dates, so lead time decides when each campaign has to run. ON A CALL <i>What's your usual lead time for summer? If guests book months out, spring is when we need to be in front of them.</i>
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Booking curve The shape reservations accumulate in ahead of a stay date, which differs by segment.	WHY THE OWNER CARES Shows when each kind of guest books, which tells the owner when marketing has to be in front of them. ON A CALL <i>Your booking curve shows when each type of guest books, so we can time the ads to match.</i>
Pace How fast bookings are arriving for a future date against last year or target.	WHY THE OWNER CARES The earliest warning of a soft month, while there's still time to do something about it. ON A CALL <i>How is October pacing against last year? That tells us whether to push now or hold.</i>
Effective OTB On-the-books weighted for expected cancellation. FORMULA $OTB \times (1 - \text{expected cancellation rate})$	WHY THE OWNER CARES A truer picture of what's really coming. A calendar full of refundable bookings made far out is both cheaper and more fragile than it looks. ON A CALL <i>Once we allow for likely cancellations, your effective OTB for October is a bit lower than it looks.</i>
Transient vs group Individual bookings versus contracted blocks — two different businesses inside one property.	WHY THE OWNER CARES Group business brings volume in one contract but can push out higher-paying individual guests, so the mix decides how exposed the owner is if one group cancels. ON A CALL <i>Is most of your business transient or group? The two need very different marketing.</i>

04 Direct bookings and distribution

Why a direct booking is worth more than its price.

Metasearch Google Hotel Ads, Tripadvisor, Trivago — rate comparison that passes traffic on to a booking channel.	WHY THE OWNER CARES Where guests compare the owner's direct price against the OTAs side by side, so showing up there with a direct rate wins bookings that would otherwise go to Expedia or Booking.com. ON A CALL <i>Guests comparing prices on Google or Tripadvisor are on metasearch — are you showing up there with your direct rate?</i>
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First-party data

Guest data the property owns outright, which is most of why direct matters.

WHY THE OWNER CARES

Owning the guest relationship means repeat stays without paying commission again, and it's a big part of what makes direct bookings worth more than their price.

ON A CALL

Every direct booking gives you first-party data — the guest's email is yours, not the OTA's.

Effective commission

EC

The full cost of winning a booking as a percentage of its value, so a direct booking and an OTA booking compare on one line.

FORMULA Total cost of winning the booking ÷ Gross booking value

WHY THE OWNER CARES

Puts a direct booking and an OTA booking on one line as a percentage of the stay, which is the comparison owners actually care about — and unlike an OTA contract, it's a cost HGM can improve.

ON A CALL

Once we count ad spend and discounts too, what's your effective commission on a direct booking compared with Booking.com?

05 Marketing measurement

Whether the ads are working, and how we can tell.

CPM

cost per mille — cost per thousand impressions

Cost per thousand impressions — the ad number an owner is most likely to quote at you.

FORMULA (Ad spend ÷ Impressions) × 1,000

WHY THE OWNER CARES

The ad number owners are most likely to quote at you. On its own it says what attention costs, not whether the ads brought bookings.

ON A CALL

Your CPM went up this month, which usually means we're competing with more advertisers for the same people.

UTM

urchin tracking module link tags

Link tags that make traffic traceable.

WHY THE OWNER CARES

Makes it possible to show the owner which post, email or ad brought each booking, rather than asking them to take it on trust.

ON A CALL

We tag every link with a UTM so we can see exactly which post or email brought each booking.

CAPI

conversions API

Server-side event sending, which survives the browser blocking the pixel.

WHY THE OWNER CARES

Keeps bookings visible to the ad platform when browsers block the pixel, so the owner's campaigns are judged and optimised on real results.

ON A CALL

With CAPI connected, bookings still get reported even when a guest's browser blocks the pixel.

Incrementality

Whether a booking actually happened because of the advertising, or would have happened anyway.

WHY THE OWNER CARES

Answers whether the owner's ad money created bookings or just took credit for ones that were coming anyway.

ON A CALL

The real test is incrementality — did the ads bring in bookings that wouldn't have happened anyway?

Cannibalization

When an ad, promotion or channel takes bookings the resort would have gotten anyway, instead of creating new ones. The numbers look like growth, but revenue has only moved around, often at a higher cost.

WHY THE OWNER CARES

Makes marketing look like growth when revenue has only moved around, often at a higher cost; it's the owner's reasonable fear that they're paying for guests they'd have had anyway.

ON A CALL

Before we celebrate the promo, let's check for cannibalization — were those guests going to book anyway?

06 Tools and systems

The software a property runs on. Vendor names are in the Client Tech Stack Guide.

The tools map

PMS, channel manager, booking engine, dynamic pricing — what each does and which names sit where.

WHY THE OWNER CARES

Knowing which systems the owner runs tells you what HGM can connect to and where their data lives.

ON A CALL

Which PMS, channel manager and booking engine are you on? That tells us what we can connect to.

Rate shopping and market intelligence tools

Watching comp-set rates automatically; Lighthouse, formerly OTA Insight.

WHY THE OWNER CARES

Shows the owner what the market is charging each night, which is context rather than a pricing rule.

ON A CALL

A rate shopping tool would show you what the resorts around you are charging each night.

CRM tools

Where guest data is held and segmented for marketing; Revinate, Cendyn.

WHY THE OWNER CARES

Where the owner's guest list lives, and the difference between a one-time guest and a relationship.

ON A CALL

Which CRM tool holds your guest list? We could use it to invite past guests back.

Guest messaging tools

Pre-arrival and in-stay messaging to the guest; Duve, and Whistle (now part of Cloudbeds).

WHY THE OWNER CARES

Keeps the guest experience personal as the property grows, and gives the owner a pre-arrival moment to sell extras.

ON A CALL

Your guest messaging tool is a good place to offer upgrades before arrival.

Upsell tools

Paid upgrades before and at arrival; Oaky (part of Plusgrade since 2025).

WHY THE OWNER CARES

Adds revenue per stay automatically, without staff having to sell.

ON A CALL

An upsell tool can offer a room upgrade automatically a few days before check-in.

SUGGESTIONS, NOT SCRIPTS

Owners

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The call lines are ways in, not lines to read out. Everything here comes word for word from the HGM Industry Acumen Dictionary, where every other term lives.